FREE CARDS

Conversation Starter Cards for Parents

Cut-out cards to start short, calm chats about bodies and relationships at predictable times, grouped by age, with scripts for when you do not know the answer.

WHO IT IS FOR
Parents and carers of autistic children and young people. Teachers and SNAs may also find them useful.

NCCA STAGE
Primary · Junior Cycle (for parents and carers)

Easy read

Short chats are best. Pick a calm time. If you do not know, say: "Good question. I will find out."

How to use this resource

- Cut out the cards and keep them in the car, the bathroom or by the bed. Pick **one card** at a time.
- Choose a predictable moment: bath time, a car journey, bedtime, or after something on TV. Keep it to a few minutes.
- Use short, literal sentences and correct words: penis, vulva, breasts, periods. Say the same thing in the same way every time.
- Use page 4 if you do not know the answer. Come back to it later. A short, honest answer is enough.

© 2026 Autism & Me (autismandme.ie). Free to print and share for non-commercial educational use.

Version 1.0 · conversation-starters-card

Cards for ages 4 to 8 (younger primary)

Pick a card. Read the line, then listen. If your child changes the subject, that is fine. Try again another day.



Bath time

"Your body belongs to you. Some parts are private. They are the parts covered by underwear."

© autismandme.ie



Bath time

"The right names are penis, testicles, vulva and bottom. Every body part has a name."

© autismandme.ie



Bathroom

"The bathroom is a private place. We close the door. We knock before we open it."

© autismandme.ie



Bedtime

"If anything ever feels wrong, you can tell me. You will not be in trouble."

© autismandme.ie



Bedtime

"Who are your safe adults? Let us name five."

© autismandme.ie



In the car

"Did you notice anyone being kind today? Did anyone make you feel worried?"

© autismandme.ie



After a TV moment

"That baby grew in a womb. Bodies make babies in a way we can talk about when you are older."

© autismandme.ie



Hugs

"You choose who you hug. You can wave, high five or say no thanks."

© autismandme.ie



Secrets

"A surprise is happy and ends soon. A secret that worries you is one to tell me."

© autismandme.ie

Cards for ages 9 to 12 (older primary and first year)



In the car

"Your body is going to change. It happens to everyone, at different times. What have you heard?"

© autismandme.ie



Bathroom

"As bodies grow, we need deodorant and a daily wash. Shall we choose one together?"

© autismandme.ie



Bedtime

"Some bodies have periods. Blood comes from the vagina for a few days each month. It is normal."

© autismandme.ie



After a TV moment

"People in that show kissed. Real relationships need respect, kindness and both people saying yes."

© autismandme.ie



On the tablet

"If you see something online that upsets you, you can tell me. You will not lose the tablet for telling."

© autismandme.ie



Photos

"Never send a photo of your body to anyone. If someone asks, say no and tell me."

© autismandme.ie



Friends

"A good friend says yes and no. A good friend accepts your no."

© autismandme.ie



Feelings

"When your body feels worried, what do you notice? Tummy? Heart? Hands?"

© autismandme.ie



Questions

"You can ask me anything about bodies. If I do not know, I will find out with you."

© autismandme.ie

Cards for ages 13 and up (Junior Cycle)



In the car

"Consent means both people clearly say yes, and either person can change their mind."

© autismandme.ie



Bedtime

"Puberty can feel strange. What has changed for you? What has been hard?"

© autismandme.ie



On the phone

"Sharing a sexual image of someone under 18 is against the law, even if it is of yourself. Tell me if anyone asks."

© autismandme.ie



After a TV moment

"Love in shows is not always how it is in real life. What would a kind relationship look like?"

© autismandme.ie



Health

"You can talk to the GP about anything on your own, or with me. Would you like to know how?"

© autismandme.ie



Safe

"No one has the right to touch you if you do not want it. If it happens, tell me or a safe adult."

© autismandme.ie



Attraction

"People can like boys, girls, both, neither or someone else. All of it is okay. You can tell me."

© autismandme.ie



Pressure

"If anyone pressures you, say: 'No. I am not ready.' You can leave and call me."

© autismandme.ie



Anything

"There is nothing you cannot tell me. I will listen first and stay calm."

© autismandme.ie

If you do not know the answer

Children ask surprising questions at surprising moments. You do not need to know every answer. A calm reply teaches that the subject is safe to talk about.

You do not know the answer.

Good question. I do not know. Let us find out together.

It is not the right place or time.

That is a good question. I will answer it at home, in the car or at bedtime.

You feel embarrassed.

This is a bit hard for me to say, but it is important. I will do my best.

The question is too big for today.

That is a big question. Here is the short answer. We can talk more later.

Your child asks something that worries you.

Thank you for asking me. Where did you hear that?

You answered badly and want to try again.

I was thinking about what you asked. Can I explain it again?

Tips

- **Keep it short.** One idea at a time. A chat of one to three minutes is enough.
- **Keep it literal.** Say what you mean. Avoid sayings such as "the birds and the bees". Use the real words.
- **Be predictable.** Same time, same place, same words. Use pictures, drawings or a book if your child prefers.
- **Let them lead.** If they change the subject or want to stop, let them. Come back later.
- **Come back to it.** Repeat the same message often. Children need to hear it many times, in many places.
- **Stay calm.** If you react strongly, your child may stop asking. Say: "Thank you for telling me."
- **Write it down.** Some children find it easier to write or use a card, a text or a drawing.

© Autism & Me · autismandme.ie

Notes for adults

- Chats at predictable times help autistic children, who often find unplanned, face-to-face talk harder. Side-by-side talk (in the car, while walking) can feel easier than eye contact.
- Do not wait until your child asks. Many autistic children do not ask, or do not know what to ask. Offer information early and repeat it. Correct anatomical names protect children: they can tell someone clearly if something happens.
- Teach the **public and private** rule, **safe adults** and **telling** from the start. The key messages are: we all have the right to feel safe, and nothing is so awful that we can't talk about it with someone we trust.
- Describe bodies inclusively where it is helpful: "some bodies have a penis, some have a vulva". Avoid shame. Avoid assuming what your child can or cannot understand.
- Work with the school. Ask what is being taught in SPHE and RSE, and when. Agree the same words at home and school.
- For support, Parentline is on 01 873 3500. HSE sexualwellbeing.ie has information for parents and young people. Your GP or public health nurse can also help.

autismandme.ie

Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand units *Taking care of my body*, *Growing and changing* and *Safety and protection*; supported by the Stay Safe programme and the RSE programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality** and Strand 1 **Understanding Myself and Others**.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: home and school working together, with consistent language and visual supports.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

HSE Sexual Wellbeing

Free information, free STI testing and free contraception information at sexualwellbeing.ie.

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Webwise

Online safety advice for parents, teachers and young people at webwise.ie.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

autismandme.ie

© 2026 Autism & Me, Waterford, Ireland. Text, illustrations and design © autismandme.ie. You may print and share this resource free of charge for non-commercial educational use, with this notice kept in place. It may not be sold, changed or republished without written permission. This resource gives general information and does not replace medical, legal or safeguarding advice. Phone numbers and services were checked in October 2026; please confirm them locally before you share. Feedback: contactautismandme@gmail.com